

Less is more

Ludwig Mies van der Rohe, remembered as one of the 20th century's greatest architects, is also associated with the phrase 'less is more'. He was not, however, the first to use it; credit for that goes to Peter Behrens, who employed young Mies to collaborate on the AEG turbine factory in Berlin (1907–10). According to Mies: 'I heard it in Behrens's office for the first time. I had to make a drawing for a façade for a factory ... I showed him a bunch of drawings of what could be done and then he said, "Less is more," but he meant it in another way than I use it.' Mies used the phrase often, effectively making it his own, as he reduced and distilled buildings and their components into simple, integrated forms. Like several other contemporary architects, he sought to create a new architectural style to exemplify modern times, and his focus on simplified components and minimal ornamentation led to designs featuring multifaceted buildings of glass, steel and glazed curtain walls that blurred the boundaries between interiors and exteriors.



330 North Wabash in Chicago, Van der Rohe, 1969–73